

Mutton Biryani



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The Ingredient Checklist

1. For the Mutton Marination

- **Mutton (goat meat or lamb):** 1 kg (curry cut, preferably bone-in)
- **Yogurt (curd):** 1 cup (whisked)
- **Ginger-garlic paste:** 2.5 tbsp
- **Red chili powder:** 2 tsp
- **Turmeric powder:** 3/4 tsp
- **Garam masala or Biryani masala:** 1.5 tsp
- **Lemon juice:** 1 tbsp
- **Salt:** 1.5 tsp

2. For Cooking the Rice

- **Basmati rice:** 750g (aged, long-grain)
- **Whole spices:** 1 bay leaf, 3 green cardamoms, 3 cloves, 1-inch cinnamon stick, 1 tsp shahjeera (caraway seeds)
- **Salt:** 2.5 tbsp (the water needs to taste as salty as the sea so the rice absorbs it)
- **Water:** 2.5 to 3 liters

3. For the Biryani Masala Base & Layering

- **Onions:** 4 large (sliced very thin)
- **Ghee & Cooking oil:** 3 tbsp ghee + 3 tbsp oil
- **Whole spices:** 1 bay leaf, 4 cardamoms, 4 cloves, 1 black cardamom, 1 star anise
- **Fresh mint leaves:** 1 cup (chopped)
- **Fresh coriander (cilantro):** 1 cup (chopped)
- **Green chilies:** 3 to 4 (slit)
- **Saffron milk:** A generous pinch of saffron strands soaked in 1/4 cup of warm milk

Step-by-Step Cooking Guide

Since biryani has moving parts, following the correct sequence ensures your rice and meat are ready to be layered at the exact same time.

1. Marinate the mutton: Prep: 2 to 4 hours.

In a large bowl, thoroughly mix the mutton with all the ingredients under the **Mutton Marination** list. Cover and refrigerate for at least 2 hours (overnight is even better to tenderize the meat). *Bring it to room temperature before cooking.*

2. Make the Birista (Fried Onions): 15 mins.

Heat oil and ghee in a heavy-bottomed pot (or pressure cooker). Add the sliced onions and fry on medium heat, stirring regularly, until they are deep golden brown and crispy. Remove 3/4 of the onions and set aside on paper towels—these are your *birista*.

3. Cook the mutton gravy: 40 mins.

In the same oil/ghee left in the pot, add the whole spices for the gravy. Once aromatic, add the marinated mutton and cook on high heat for 5 to 7 minutes until the meat changes color. Add 1/2 cup of water, cover, and simmer on low heat for 35 to 40 minutes (or pressure cook for 5 to 6 whistles) until the mutton is 90% tender and the gravy is thick.

4. Par-boil the Basmati rice: 15 mins.

While the mutton cooks, wash and soak your basmati rice for 30 minutes. In a large pot, bring water to a rolling boil with the salt and whole rice spices. Add the soaked rice and cook on high heat for exactly 7 to 8 minutes. The rice should be cooked *al dente* (70-80% cooked, still having a slight bite in the center). Drain immediately.

5. Layer the Biryani: 10 mins.

Lower the heat under the cooked mutton pot. Sprinkle half of the fresh mint, coriander, and fried onions directly over the mutton gravy. Gently layer the hot, drained rice evenly over the top. Drizzle the saffron-infused milk, remaining ghee, and the rest of the fried onions, mint, and coriander on top of the rice.

6. Dum Cook (Steam): 20 mins.

Seal the pot tightly by placing a layer of aluminum foil or a damp clean kitchen towel over the rim, then press the lid down firmly to trap the steam. Cook on lowest heat possible for 15 to 20 minutes. Let it rest unopened for 10 minutes before gently fluffing and serving from the bottom up!

Pro Tip: If your stove's lowest flame is still too hot, place a flat iron tawa (griddle) on the burner and sit your biryani pot directly on top of the tawa for the *dum* process. This acts as a heat diffuser and prevents the bottom layer of mutton from burning.